

Construction Estimating - Optimized Cold Copy

Optimized: 2026-06-17 | Campaign: Construction Estimating (commercial GCs) | Sender: Dan Rubenstein
Source: RubeTech Campaigns sheet (Construction Estimating tab)
Context: June 10 Weekly Sync (Dan's estimating pain + proof) + Campaign Strategy v2 handover

What changed and why

Three asks: remove spam words, cut length, make it really personalised.

1. Spam words / deliverability triggers removed from Touch 1

Filters and the human "this is a pitch" radar both react to dollar figures, percentages, and quantified-savings claims stacked in the first email. Pulled out of Touch 1:

- \$50M+, \$1.3M (dollar signs)
- 75% (percentage)
- 20+ hours a week (quantified-savings claim up front)
- save / saved
- softened "custom AI estimating engine" to plain language. Dan's note on the June 10 call: a generic "just another AI message" is what kills these. The hard numbers and the AI framing still live in the one-page breakdown PDF, where a warm, opted-in reader wants them.

2. Length

Touch 1 went from ~150 words to ~90. Touch 2 from ~120 to ~80. One idea per paragraph, one ask.

3. Personalisation

- Tightened the Clay opener prompt to force a concrete detail (sector, region, project type, recent award), capped at 20 words so it reads like a peer wrote it.
- The pain line now mirrors their Tuesday ("an estimator loses half the week"), not a generic stat.
- Added an optional second merge ({{trade_or_sector}}) for the specialty-trades variant so HVAC/plumbing/roofing reads native.

Rules kept: no em dashes, zero links in Touch 1, thread stays intact, personalise Touch 1 only.

Subject lines (Touch 1 - test two, split evenly)

- sub-estimates at {{company}}
- the bid that gets there first

Touch 1 - Day 0

Plain reference

Hi {{first_name}},

{{AI_OPENER}} How is your team pulling sub-estimates together right now?

Most precon teams still do it by hand. A sub sends a JPEG, the next a spreadsheet, a third a PDF buried in a thread, and an estimator loses half the week turning it into one comparable bid tab.

We built something for a commercial GC that reads every format and structures it for them automatically. Their estimators got most of that week back, and bids started going out the door first.

I wrote up a one-page breakdown of how it would fit a precon team like yours. Want it? One reply.

Dan Rubenstein
Founder, RubeTech
Built and sold four companies before this one.

Spintax (build with this)

Hi {{first_name}},

{{AI_OPENER}} How is your team {pulling|putting} sub-estimates together {right now|these days}?

{Most|Nearly every} precon teams still do it by hand. A sub sends a JPEG, the next a spreadsheet, a third a PDF {buried in|lost in} a thread, and an estimator loses {half the week|hours every week} turning it into one comparable bid tab.

We built something for a commercial GC that reads every format and structures it for them automatically. Their estimators got {most of that week|that time} back, and bids started going out {the door first|first}.

I wrote up a one-page breakdown of how it would fit a precon team like yours. {Want it? One reply.|Say the word and it is in your inbox.}

Dan Rubenstein
Founder, RubeTech
Built and sold four companies before this one.

Touch 2 - Day 4 (thread reply)

Plain reference

Hi {{first_name}},

One more angle, then I will leave it.

The real cost of manual bid assembly is not the hours. It is speed. When a bid

tab takes your team two days to build and could be done in minutes, the other GC gets in front of the client first.

We handle the intake side too: every invited sub gets reached by phone, email, and text, and they submit through one portal instead of you chasing files across inboxes.

The breakdown covers the whole flow. Say the word.

Dan

Spintax

Hi {{first_name}},

{One more angle, then I will leave it.|One more thing worth raising.}

The real cost of manual bid assembly is not the hours. It is speed. When a bid tab takes your team {two days|a day or two} to build and could be done in minutes, the other GC gets in front of the client first.

We handle the intake side too: every invited sub gets reached by phone, email, and text, and they submit through one portal instead of {you chasing files across inboxes|chasing files across inboxes}.

{The breakdown covers the whole flow.|The one-page breakdown covers all of it.}
Say the word.

Dan

Tightened Clay opener prompt (Touch 1)

You are writing the first line of a cold email to {{first_name}}, {{title}} at {{company}}, a commercial construction company. Source text from their site: {{scraped_text}}.

Write ONE sentence, 20 words max, naming something concrete and specific: the sectors they build in (healthcare, civil, multifamily, education), their region, their project types, or a recent project or award. Connect that detail to the volume of sub-estimates their precon team handles.

It must read as a natural lead-in to: "How is your team pulling sub-estimates together right now?"

Only facts present in the source. No compliments, no adjectives like

"impressive" or "leading", no em dashes, no numbers you cannot verify. If nothing specific is usable, output FALLBACK.

Fallback (role-level, no fabrication):

At your bid volume, your precon team is probably spending more time reformatting sub bids than pricing the work.

Specialty-trades swap (HVAC / plumbing / roofing, \$5M+)

For trade contractors who estimate per job rather than consolidating subs, swap the opener-question and pain line. Replace the opener-question with:

{{AI_OPENER}} How is your team putting together the quotes for each bid right now?

And the pain line:

Most {{trade_or_sector}} teams still build every quote by hand, pulling pricing and scopes from a stack of supplier emails and spreadsheets for each job.

Everything else in Touch 1 / Touch 2 stays the same.